Good Guys Wear Yellow

By Daphne R. Hall

INTRODUCTION

The Question: Should we use the technology available to create human clones?

The Conservative Answer: The process is morally and ethically unacceptable "...scientists who envision medical breakthroughs using stem cells from human embryos are now moving on to human cloning -- breeding people for the purpose of harvesting their tissues and organs from their bodies, then disposing of them."

The Liberal Answer: "Human cloning allows man to fashion his own essential nature and turn chance into choice. For cloning's advocates, this is an opportunity to remake mankind in an image of health, prosperity, and nobility; it is the ultimate expression of man's unlimited potential."

In this state-of-the art debate, the good guys don't wear white and the bad guys don't wear black. In fact, in this debate, the Good Guys Wear Yellow by Daphne R. Hall

Horatio: (30s) a genetic engineer suffering from an attack of conscience
Although Horatio has devoted his professional career to improving the genetic structure of humanity, he has recently come to respect the importance of serendipity as he here describes.

HORATIO: *(Reads what he has written, after typing briefly)* To whom it may concern. Hmmm. That may be a little too formal. Let's think about this a second. *(Gets up and paces; loftily, Shakespearean.)* To whom it may concern. *(Pauses, sits.)* I guess that will simply have to do. I wouldn't have a clue who to address it to specifically, if I were going to be specific. It stands as written:

To whom it may concern. *(Pauses with fingers poised over keys, types again, stops.)* If you are reading this, and I assume you are, otherwise

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

I would be wasting my breath-or keystrokes-if you are reading this, I assume you are searching for an explanation. *(Types, stops.)* I don't feel like I owe any explanations, or owe anyone a thing, generally, but for the purposes of satiating the curious, and admittedly, satiating myself to some extent, I shall attempt to provide one. *(Pause, sips, types.)*

On second thought ... *(Pause.)* there is no explanation for what I have done. What I can offer is a series of observations and remarks, open for you to interpret your own explanation, your own answer to sew it up, your own fire in the hole. That will have to suffice. *(Runs hand through hair, sips water.)* I was recognized with a cash bonus from work last week. *(Types.)* I was also assured a promotion, next in line after the assistant to the deputy VP. of the Genetic Engineering Department retires in the fall. My supervisor slapped me on the back and said, *(Puffy southern drawl.)* "Not bad for the new kid on the block, eh?" Not bad at all. New kid. I've been the new kid for six years. *(Types, reads.)*

It is customary for any guy who has good fortune to treat the department to a round of beers after work. I guess this was expected of me as well. What is expected is not always received. The other engineers were putting their coats and hats on as slowly as possible, and some were sort of hanging by the door. I guess they were waiting for me to ask. I didn't. I pretended not to see.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

(Pause, types, reads.) I came straight back to my apartment. I thought little of it, until the next day, when I began to get the feeling that I had suddenly become rather unpopular. It is not as if I previously could have been considered popular, but now I was most definitely and unequivocally unpopular. I had moved from a neutral status to one of the extremes. I seem to have broken an unwritten rule of the work force camaraderie: *(Exaggerated fire and brimstone.)* SHARE THY SUCCESS WITH THY BROTHERS, or THOU SHALT FEEL THE WRATH. *(Beat, thoughtful.)*

Perhaps someone should write down all of the unwritten rules. *(Gets up, paces, stands and thinks while looking at a painting, returns to desk and types.)* In my profession, I, and others like me, delve into genetic possibilities every day. Upon gaining some expertise, and testing for results, these possibilities become certainties, and the randomness, along with the anticipation of discovery, dissipates. *(Slightly sarcastic.)* The previous thrill of raw, lascivious searches for true answers fades into a sophisticated defense mechanism, where one must no longer prove for the sake of proving, but instead must prove oneself to be absolutely correct in one's hypotheses and calculations. Breakthroughs have given over to accuracy wrapped up tight in a pretty box. *(Sips, types, reads excitedly)*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

In the lab, I can direct my computer to reconstruct and rearrange genes and DNA to create any type of person I-or my boss-wants to create. I am Bernstein, I am Zinman of the gene pool, conducting, pounding out a chromosomal coda, repeated over and over with subtle differences every time it is played. I can create clones, a slew of clones, if I want to. Perhaps-perhaps if Hitler had access to this knowledge, he would have approached genocide from a different angle, one more suited to the tastes of the masses. Perhaps he would have been gracious and simply sterilized all the Jews, let them die off, and created his superior race with a keyboard. *(Yiddish singsong.)* Much less messy. *(Normal voice.)* He may have been far too interested in flexing his muscles to take such a cerebral approach, but I wouldn't be here if he hadn't been so sloppy. His human capacity for error gave many of us life, directly or indirectly. And as for Hitler's successor? *(Quiet, then types, reads.)* The Union of Concerned Scientists are very concerned, as are the liberal media and the bible thumpers. Strange bedfellows. Anyway. I digress. *(Pause.)*

It took two or three years before I became weary of all this certainty. I knew what to expect when I awoke, when I arrived at work, when I came, and when I slept. No surprises. No plot twists. No nothing. About two months ago, after a long day of designing large quantities of various necessary people, I left work and found my car wouldn't start. *(Smiles.)* It was Fate, throwing a wrench into my routine and greeting me with a beckoning hand. I walked back to my

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

apartment. On the way, I passed an art supply store. I stared in the window, and started to walk on several times, but kept stopping and turning back. Finally, I resigned myself to my own curiosity and ventured in. I emerged, hours later, with bags and armfuls of materials I knew nothing about, most of which I had not the foggiest idea how to use. *(Smiles.)*

I bought them all under the advice of a smiling salesgirl with crooked teeth and an unusual nose. As I checked out, I found myself wondering how to adjust her DNA to fix those little imperfections. *(Pause.)* I lugged everything into my apartment, spread it out on the floor, and stared at it all for a long time. Weeks. I decided eventually that since I had invested the money into these things, I might as well see what they could do.

(Very expressive at this point; more use of hands and boyish enthusiasm. He is describing his transformation and rebirth.) I slashed and attacked the canvas like an amateur-which is exactly what I am. *(Types, reads.)* I let the paint fall wherever it wanted to, or wherever I felt like having it fall. Finally, I had something requiring no blueprint, something never quite complete or incomplete, something never quite perfect-random splashes holding little meaning except to me. *(Pause, stands, gestures to paintings.)* That's what I did the day I received my cash bonus, instead of taking everyone out. I came home to paint. I never thought to tell them that I was going home to paint,

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

it didn't occur to me to explain away my silent declinations. If I had, they probably would not have understood. I had never informed anyone of my activities after work. *(Pause, types, reads.)*

During the last few days of tepid relations, once I established their source, I realized that even had I known the outcome, the consequence, I would have done the same thing that evening. *(Pause, excited again.)* I have caught myself actually daydreaming at the terminal. For how long, I don't know, I just come out of it and I've been there. Through these dreams, I have concluded there is a definite and critical need for randomness and uncertainty. *(To himself, exclaims.)* Something that surprises! *(Types, then reads.)*

Yesterday, on my way home from work, again forgoing machinery for manpower, a car barreled through a mud puddle and I was thoroughly soaked. As I peeled my dripping socks from my feet, I thought, how random can you get? What is the probability that I, not anyone else, would be standing on that particular street corner at that particular moment when that particular car drove through that pothole and that the pothole would be filled with rainwater? So. The pothole brings me to today. *(Sips, types, reads silently, then paces, paper in hand.)* Today, I went to work, same as always, and carried out my routine duties. *(Slow smile.)* With a small plot twist. I decided to exert a high locus of control over a system possessing a incredible amount of control over all of us. *(Pause, pleased.)* I erased everything.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Everything. All my programs, all my data, all my notes, everything. Wiped the drive clean. I came home and burned the backup tapes. Everything. The key to success has been swallowed. *(Walks to desk, sips water.)* The Russian roulette of pure human reproduction will have to suffice, at least for a while, until the others retrace my steps and play catch-up. I took the rest of my cash bonus and made preparations to erase myself as well. *(Opens desk drawer and takes out a gun; sips water; holds up gun and spins cylinder.)* To keep me from changing my mind. *(Puts gun to temple; lights go out as there is a loud gunshot.)*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Daphne R. Hull
Book: Best Men's Stage Monologues of 1997
ISBN: 978-1575251370
Publisher: Smith and Kraus Publishers
Date (Month/Year): December 1998